



TRADE ROUTES

For centuries, the main trading routes between the continents were dictated by the oceanic winds that drove sailing ships. For example, ships such as the one above would cross from east to west in the tropics, using the easterly trade winds, and from west to east using the westerly winds that blow over cooler oceans. Modern ships don't need to worry about the wind direction, but it still pays to take advantage of ocean currents.

CONTAINER SHIP

Lightweight goods traded over long distances are often carried by air, especially perishable foods such as fruit. But heavy loads are best sent by sea, because ships are supported by the water, allowing them to carry a huge weight of cargo. The fuel they use is only needed to push them along—unlike aircraft, which must burn a lot of fuel just to stay in the air. Ships are slow, but for many cargoes this is not a problem. A fleet of ships can also act like a floating conveyor belt, delivering an almost continuous supply of cargo.

► HEAVY LOAD

A colossal load of shipping containers full of heavy freight is a standard cargo for this specialized container ship.

Ocean trade

The oceans have been trading routes for centuries, providing vital links between nations. Ships are still the best way of transporting heavy cargoes such as oil and cars, but they also carry many other trade goods. These are often loaded into big steel containers that are easily lifted off the ship and on to trucks for distribution by road.

A big cargo ship can carry more than 19,000 containers.

